Vanish Cam – build and install guide

What you get

A Windows app with a small control window. It shows up in Google Meet, Zoom, Teams and Discord as a camera called **Vanish Camera**. No OBS Studio is needed: the installer registers a small virtual-camera driver (Unity Capture, MIT licence) itself.

For you: build it (on your Windows PC)

1. Install **Python 3.11 or 3.12** from python.org (tick "Add to PATH").
2. Optional but needed for the one-click installer: install **Inno Setup 6** (free, jrsoftware.org).
3. Open the `VanishCam` folder and double-click `build.bat`. It creates its own environment, installs everything, builds the app, and (if Inno Setup is present) the installer.
4. Results: `dist\VanishCam\VanishCam.exe` (portable folder) and `installer_output\VanishCam-Setup.exe` (send this to friends).

If `build.bat` stops with an error, copy the last 20 lines and send them to me.

For your friends: install and use

1. Run `VanishCam-Setup.exe`. Windows will ask for permission once (it installs the camera driver). If SmartScreen warns, choose *More info* → *Run anyway* (the app is not code-signed).
2. Open **Vanish Cam**. Close other apps that use the webcam. Press **1. Start camera**.
3. Press **2. Capture background** and step completely out of the picture for about 5 seconds. Keep the camera and lights still.
4. Step back in. Press **3. Vanish / Reappear**, use the hotkey, or tick "Vanish when I snap my fingers".
5. In Meet / Zoom / Teams choose the camera **Vanish Camera**. Leave the Vanish Cam window open (minimised is fine) during the call.

Hotkeys work while a call has focus: Ctrl+Alt+B background, Ctrl+Alt+V vanish, Ctrl+Alt+E effect, Ctrl+Alt+S snap on/off.

Troubleshooting

- **"Vanish Camera" not in the list:** press *Repair camera driver* in the app, accept the Windows prompt, restart the call app.
- **Still visible / outline:** recapture the background (nobody in view, lights as they will be).

- **Choppy video:** run `VanishCam-console.exe --camtest` and send the output; use `--res 960x540` on slow PCs.
- **Snap not detected:** `VanishCam-console.exe --snap-test`; raise sensitivity in the window.
- **Log file:** `%APPDATA%\VanishCam\log.txt`.
- **Uninstall:** Windows Settings → Apps. This also removes the camera driver.

Honest limits

Tested here on Linux with simulated cameras, microphones and a virtual display (engine, pipeline, window, frozen build and MediaPipe model bundling). **Not tested:** the Windows build itself, the Inno installer, driver registration, and Meet/Zoom/Teams seeing "Vanish Camera". Expect a round of fixes after the first Windows build. The app is not code-signed, so SmartScreen and some antivirus programs may warn. The driver is bundled under the MIT licence (see `driver\LICENSE-UnityCapture.txt`).